A LOOMING PILOT CRISIS

WITH AIRLINES LOOKING TO EXPAND THEIR FLEET AND THE COUNTRY UNABLE TO PRODUCE FLYERS FAST ENOUGH TO KEEP UP WITH THE ESCALATING DEMAND, INDIAN AIRLINES COULD BE HEADING FOR A PILOT SHORTAGE

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A LONG HAUL AHEAD IndiGo flight crew getting trained in a cockpit simulator

AS INDIA'S AVIATION INDUSTRY PREPARES TO BECOME THE THIRD LARGEST DOMESTIC MARKET in the world and new airlines enter the competition while existing ones expand, a troubling question looms on the horizon: who will fly their planes?

Pilots are becoming a prized resource for the simple reason that there may not be enough of them soon. Currently, India has 800-plus aircraft—mostly narrowbodies—between its airlines, which employ 11,775 pilots. However, while the country was able to issue 5,700 commercial pilot licences or CPLs in the past five years, it produced only 2,982 commanders or captains, who are given the charge of an aircraft and its entire crew, in the same period. And it is a commander crunch that the country has been grappling with at present, something that the ministry has admitted to time and again. To meet the shortfall, 120 foreign commanders have been given Foreign Aircrew Temporary Authorisation (FATA) to work in various Indian airlines.

But the situation is expected to get more acute as India's aviation sector is looking to expand its fleet—primarily on the back of the growth of two of its largest carriers, IndiGo and Air India, as well as Akasa Air, which since 2015 have collectively ordered 1,976 planes. Of these, 324 had been imported by June 2024. As per the delivery schedules, another 1,147 aircraft are supposed to be inducted in phases by 2030 and the remainder by 2034. Even if we account for the existing aircraft whose lease will end in this period, a top ministry official estimates the fleet size to touch "at least 1,400 by 2029".

Thus the need for men and women to fly these new planes will escalate exponentially. To become a pilot in India, an individual has to obtain a CPL, issued by sector regulator Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA). They then have to undergo airplane-specific training—something called 'type rating'—of four months that qualifies them to take a position on the flight deck of a commercial plane. But even so, they can only be first officers or co-pilots, not the commander. To become one, they need to get an airline transport pilot licence, or ATPL. "On an average, it takes around 6-7 years of serving as a first officer to become a commander," says a senior official of the Indira Gandhi Rashtriya Uran Akademi (IGRUA)—the Union ministry of civil aviation's sole flying school, located at the Safdarjung Airport in New Delhi.

PLANE MATHEMATICS

As per the industry standard worldwide, airlines generally follow staffing norms of eight sets of pilots (a captain and a co-pilot) per narrowbody or single-aisle aircraft—such as the Boeing 737 and the A320, which ply on domestic routes. That is, 16 pilots in all to fly one plane on multiple rotations per day all year round. And if you consider long-haul international flights, the requirement can go up to 24 pilots per widebody.

India will need 10,900 additional pilots by FY 2030, according to an analysis by aviation advisory